Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Wordsworth's "To Sleep"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's attitude regarding Sleep in Wordsworth's "To Sleep," focusing especially on the names that the speaker uses to describe Sleep, include

allusion,
ambivalence (not ambiguity),
apostrophe,
litotes,
muse,
octave,
personification,
rhyme,
sigmatism,
simile,
sonnet (Italian),
speaker,
synecdoche,
turn (volta), and
tone.

Recognizing that the speaker addresses Sleep in both positive terms and negative terms, the young writer might focus simply on the ambivalence that the range of terms suggests.

That the speaker admits that he alone might be the only person unhappy with Sleep (line 11) should be noted; however, if the young writer doesn't perceive that the problem might be insomnia (Sleep is "last to come where [it is] wanted most!"), it should not be seen as a failing in an otherwise solid discussion of the complimentary descriptors and, on the other hand, the disparaging, perhaps deprecating, descriptors.

In addition to noting both the ambivalence and the possibility that insomnia might be the subject of the poem, the perceptive competitor might recognize the sonnet's sestet as something of a prayer (the sonnet is an apostrophe)—troubling and mildly desperate in tone.

The well-read Lit Critter might recognize an echo of Macbeth's praise of sleep in the "fond words" found in lines 6-7: "Balm that tames / All anguish." Indeed, he or she might perceive the sonnet's octave as a catalogue of praise by poets past and the octave as a rebuttal of a history of praise in an attempt to induce Sleep to come to the speaker's aid.